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EU AI Act

Netherlands

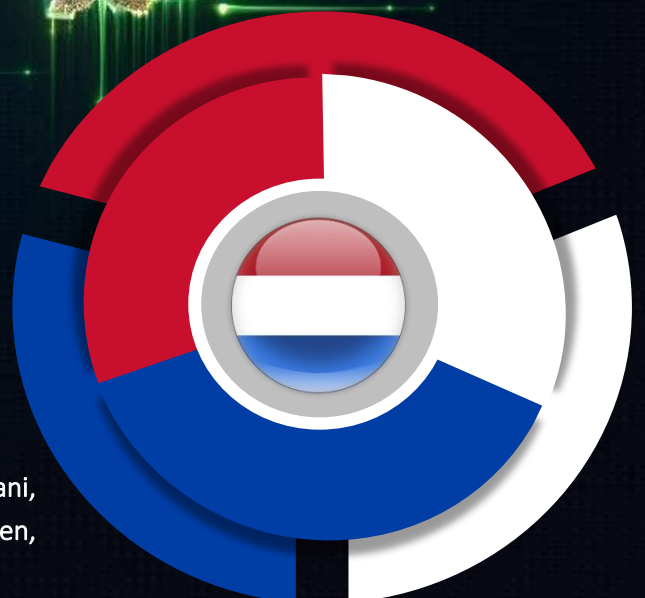
AI Ecosystem Brief

November 2025



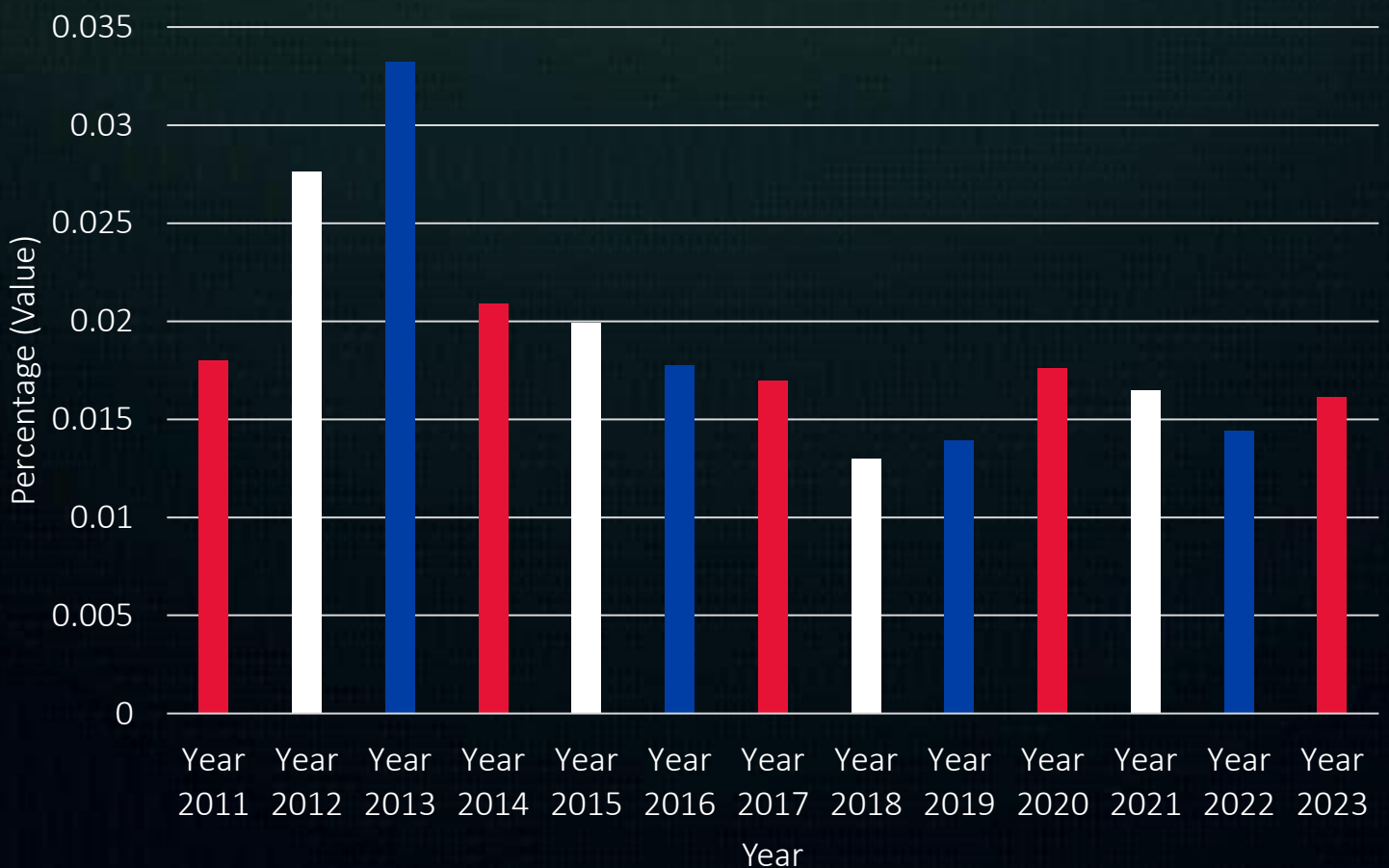
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Reinforcing the Netherlands' AI Innovation Momentum: Strategic Imperatives to Counter Plateauing Research Contribution, Deepen Private-Sector Uptake, and Sustain Global Leadership Beyond 2020

Percentage of global GitHub contributions to public AI projects originating from the Netherlands (November 2025)



Explanation: The chart shows how much of the total work on AI projects globally comes from Dutch developers between 2011-2023. For example, in 2013, 0.033% of global projects were committed by Dutch developers.

Between 2011 and 2023, the Netherlands' share of AI projects (based on fractional contribution counts) reveals an early expansion followed by stagnation. From 0.018 in 2011, Dutch participation climbed steadily to a peak of 0.033 in 2013, reflecting the country's strong early positioning in European AI research and the mobilization of academic–industry partnerships under the *Strategic Action Plan for Artificial Intelligence (SAPAI)*. However, after 2014, participation declined and stabilized in a narrow range between 0.013 and 0.018, suggesting a levelling-off of relative influence within the global AI research ecosystem.

This plateau signals a maturing but capacity-constrained landscape. The initial surge corresponded with the establishment of early AI hubs and the growth of Dutch innovation ecosystems around universities such as Delft, Eindhoven, and Amsterdam. Yet, subsequent years saw increased international competition and the rapid scaling of AI investment in larger economies—particularly the United States and China—reducing the Netherlands' proportional share. While national initiatives like the AIC4NL, NOLAI, and the Dutch Digitalisation Strategy have successfully strengthened coordination and ethical AI development, the data suggest that overall project representation has not kept pace with the accelerating global research volume.

Several structural factors underpin this stagnation: limited domestic R&D scale, dependency on European funding cycles, and modest private-sector engagement relative to public research institutions. The Netherlands' strengths in responsible AI and data governance are clear, yet these areas need stronger commercial translation. Without broader industrial adoption and sustained investment in applied AI research, the country risks losing visibility in the global innovation map.

Constructively, this trend presents a pivotal opportunity. To reverse stagnation and reinforce competitiveness, the Netherlands should:

1. Scale applied research translation: Expand incentives for SMEs to partner with academic AI labs and convert research outcomes into deployable products and services.
2. Invest in next-generation infrastructure: Strengthen access to high-performance computing and federated data spaces to support advanced AI experimentation.

3. Enhance international co-publication networks: Leverage EU partnerships and Horizon Europe frameworks to boost collaborative output visibility.
4. Expand the talent pipeline: Broaden AI education pathways and retention incentives for PhD graduates to prevent skill outflow to larger economies.
5. Track and publish AI output metrics: Public dissemination of annual AI contribution indicators can help monitor progress and signal leadership transparency.

In short, while the Netherlands retains a robust and ethically grounded AI ecosystem, the flattening of its research contribution share underscores the need for renewed momentum. Strategic scaling of innovation capacity, industrial participation, and data-driven monitoring will be essential for sustaining the Netherlands' role as a European frontrunner in responsible, high-impact artificial intelligence.



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Who Are We

AI That You Can Trust

Why Us?

Stay on the right side of history. At AI & Partners, we believe AI should unlock potential—not cause harm. We've seen the fear and fallout when teams lose control of AI, but also the trust and innovation that follow when it's handled responsibly. That's why we exist: to help you build AI you can trust and stand behind—for the long run.

80%

of AI systems
are unknown

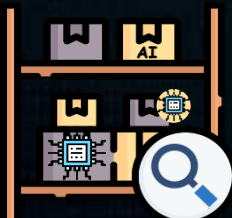
What Do We Do?

We enable safe AI usage—for your organization and your clients. Unknown AI adoption leads to confusion, risk, and reputational damage. We help you take control with tools to identify, monitor, and govern all AI systems—so you're not reacting to AI, you're leading it.

How Do We Do It?

Do you know what AI systems you have? Identify all known and unknown AI systems (algorithms, LLMs, prompts, and models) from all internal and external AI vendors, automated by generating your inventory. Overall, 80% of AI inventory is unknown to our clients.

How do you guarantee ongoing safe AI use? Continuously monitor deployed AI systems for performance drift, anomalies or failures, real-world impacts, and emerging risks (e.g. data poisoning). Any malfunction of an AI system has severe implications for organisations (e.g. inability to assess online misinformation that leads to widespread public mistrust), so monitoring becomes a matter of urgency.



AI Discovery & AI Inventory

Automatically detect all AI systems, including models, algorithms, and prompts, and maintain a live, always-updated register for full visibility and compliance.



Responsible AI

Embed fairness, transparency, and control into every stage of AI use—aligning with the EU AI Act and building 'Trustworthy-by-Design'.



Model Monitoring

Continuously track your AI models after deployment to detect drift, bias, or failure—so you stay in control and prevent harm before it happens.

Contents

This section outlines the structure of the report, detailing chapters on the Netherlands' AI policy landscape, regulatory initiatives, governance mechanisms, findings, and recommendations. It serves as a navigation guide, enabling readers to quickly locate specific analyses, datasets, and policy discussions relevant to the Netherlands' evolving artificial intelligence ecosystem.

Who Are We	4
Contents.....	5
Overview.....	7
Specific AI Governance or Law	9
Specific AI Governance in Netherlands	9
AI Ethics Guidelines and Sectoral Governance Tools	10
Proposed AI Regulatory Authority and Future Outlook	11
Dutch National.....	12
AI Strategy	12
Approach to	14
AI Regulation	14

1. Regulatory and Strategic Frameworks	14
2. Institutional Support and Strategic Missions	15
3. Standards Development and Global Engagement	15
4. Sectoral and Extended Regulatory Approaches	15
5. Fostering Innovation and Indigenous Development.....	16
6. AI in Public-Sector Transformation.....	16
7. AI Skills, Education and Inclusion	17
8. Infrastructure, Compute and Data Foundations	17
Approach to Foster Innovation	18
1. Unlocking Economic Value through Targeted AI Deployment	18
2. Catalysing Innovation through Strategic Clustering and Ecosystems	19
3. Enabling Trusted and Responsible Data Use	19
4. Scaling AI in the Public Sector	19
5. Advancing Compute and Research Infrastructure	19
6. Empowering SMEs and Startups.....	19
7. Developing a Future-Ready Workforce	19
8. Aligning AI Innovation with Sustainability Goals	20
9. Building Public Trust and Ethical AI	20
10. Shaping Global AI Governance and Standards.....	20
Digital Decade 2025: Report	21
Government AI Readiness.....	24
Conclusion	28
Appendix A: Expert Vignettes	30
Sigrid Berge van Rooijen, <i>Health AI Consultant</i> , Eir Health	31
Biography.....	31
Arnoud Engelfriet, <i>Chief Knowledge Officer</i> , ICTRecht	32
Biography.....	32
Jousef Murad, <i>Founder & Lead Engineer</i> , APEX Consulting	33
Biography.....	34
Appendix B: OECD AI Progress Report.....	35
Strengths.....	35
Constraints and risks	36
Practical recommendations (constructive next steps).....	36
References	38

Overview

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is reshaping economies and governance worldwide, and the Netherlands is establishing itself as a proactive advocate of ethical and human-centric AI within the European Union.

Anchored in the EU's evolving regulatory landscape, the Netherlands has adopted a supervisory-first, alignment-driven approach that emphasizes rights-based safeguards, regulatory experimentation, and international cooperation. Rather than introducing standalone AI legislation, the Netherlands is leveraging strategic frameworks, the SAPAI, and soft-law instruments to promote trustworthy AI development.

At the heart of the Netherlands' evolving AI governance strategy is the ongoing process of designating national authorities responsible for overseeing and enforcing compliance with EU fundamental rights legislation in the context of AI. The list of authorities is expected to include the Netherlands Institute for Human Rights, the AP, and certain judicial authorities. A distinctive feature of the Netherlands' approach is its advocacy for the use of regulatory sandboxes, which allow for responsible AI deployment and provide a learning environment for piloting high-risk AI systems. These are complemented by strategic resources such as the SAPAI and the Dutch government's vision on generative AI.

The Netherlands' foreseeable governance model will be underpinned by a robust and multi-actor institutional architecture. The Dutch Data Protection Authority

(AP) is set to play a central role as the "market supervisor" for high-risk AI systems, tasked with ensuring compliance. The Digital Regulation Cooperation Platform (SDT), launched by the Dutch Consumer & Market Authority (ACM), Dutch Financial Markets Authority (AFM), Autoriteit Persoonsgegevens (AP), and Dutch Media Authority (CvdM), will further facilitate coordinated enforcement and knowledge sharing in the digital sector. These efforts will reflect a whole-of-society approach to embedding AI governance within national goals such as public sector modernization, digital upskilling, and inclusive economic development. The Netherlands also shows strong commitment to international standards. The country aligns closely with EU-wide strategies like the European AI Progress and actively participates in initiatives such as the Hiroshima AI Process and the UN AI Advisory Body. The Netherlands co-hosted the Responsible AI in the Military Domain (REAIM) Summit in 2023, further demonstrating its commitment to shaping global AI governance. Through these channels, the Netherlands ensures its domestic practices remain interoperable and globally relevant, reinforcing its image as a constructive contributor to human-centric AI governance.

Aligned with the SAPAI, the country is targeting key sectors—including healthcare, public services, and finance—for AI-enabled transformation. Strategic clusters and policy instruments such as the Ministry of Finance's research framework for mapping algorithmic control guide practical, accountable deployment. The SAPAI also emphasizes excellent educational opportunities to engage with AI and to cultivate more talent in the field, helping build a skilled, future-ready workforce.

The Netherlands' data and infrastructure capabilities also reinforce its AI readiness. Investments in high-quality digital and intelligent connectivity and computing power, alignment with EU instruments such as the Data Governance Act and the Data Act, and increased focus on data mobility within the financial sector underscore a future-facing commitment to scalable, trustworthy data use. Through this combination of EU-aligned oversight, innovation-driven approaches, and globally harmonized ethics frameworks, the Netherlands is building a comprehensive, adaptive model of AI governance. As a result of prioritizing human rights, transparency, and practical application, the Netherlands is charting a pragmatic course toward AI that is both innovative and democratically grounded.

Specific AI Governance or Law

The Netherlands is implementing the EU AI Act and has designated authorities like the AP and the Netherlands Institute for Human Rights for oversight. It promotes regulatory sandboxes and human-centred AI. A 2024 report recommends collaborative, sector-specific supervision, with the AP as market supervisor for high-risk AI systems.

Specific AI Governance in Netherlands

Rather than adopting sweeping standalone legislation, the Netherlands is implementing the EU AI Act directly. The EU AI Act came into effect on August 1, 2024. Pursuant to the AI Act, each Member State must publish a list of government authorities responsible for overseeing and enforcing compliance with EU fundamental rights legislation (e.g., non-discrimination, data protection) in the context of AI. Because this requirement took longer than expected to fulfil, the Netherlands missed the original November 2, 2024 deadline but received a short extension from the European Commission. The Ministry of the Interior and Kingdom Relations and Ministry of Justice and Security conducted an inventory to identify which authorities should be on the list. The list currently includes: the Netherlands Institute for Human Rights; the AP; and certain judicial authorities (e.g., the Procurator General at the Supreme Court, the Administrative Jurisdiction Division of the Council of State). Additional authorities may be added later if needed. From August 2, 2026, these listed authorities will gain certain powers under the AI Regulation, such as requesting documentation on high-risk AI systems and cooperating with specialised AI supervisory bodies. To foster

innovation while preparing for compliance, the Netherlands advocates for the use of regulatory sandboxes to ensure responsible AI deployment.

The Netherlands is also building long-term supervisory capacity. In November 2024, the Dutch Inspection of Digital Infrastructure (“RDI”) published its report titled “Final Advice on the Organisation of AI Supervision in the Netherlands,” which outlines recommendations for the governance and supervision of AI systems in the Netherlands. The report emphasises the need for collaboration between various supervisory authorities, with both centralised and sector-specific oversight. The AP is designated as the “market supervisor” for high-risk AI systems, tasked with ensuring compliance with principles such as transparency and human oversight. Specific sectoral supervisors are mentioned to oversee AI applications within their respective domains. For instance, the Health and Youth Care Inspectorate (IGJ) is suggested to monitor AI in healthcare, such as medical diagnostics and treatment plans, to ensure safety and effectiveness, while the Netherlands Food and Consumer Product Safety Authority (NVWA) is proposed to oversee AI impacting food safety and consumer products, ensuring these technologies meet relevant safety standards.

Complementing these instruments is the Dutch government's emphasis on a “human-centred approach” to AI, which means that respect for public values based on human rights is the starting point behind the purpose, design and use of AI. AI should reinforce public values and human rights rather than weaken them.

AI Ethics Guidelines and Sectoral Governance Tools

In the absence of AI-specific national legislation, the Netherlands uses a layered model rooted in the EU AI Act and reinforced by existing domestic rules on data protection, cybersecurity, consumer protection, labor law and product safety. In January 2024, the Dutch government presented a broad, government-wide vision on generative AI in response to a parliamentary motion. This vision underscores the need for action to harness both the opportunities and challenges of this rapidly evolving technology. It emphasises that generative AI should serve human wellbeing, prosperity, sustainability, justice and security, but also emphasises the importance of taking action regarding the challenges and risks of AI. It also focuses on ongoing partnerships (e.g., with the AIC4NL and increased international cooperation). The Toolbox for Ethically Responsible Innovation, developed by the Ministry of the Interior and Kingdom Relations in 2019, helps developers and administrators innovate ethically, respecting public values and

fundamental rights. Based on seven core principles, the toolbox provides advice and references to "tools" such as models, methods, guidelines, and practical examples. The seven core principles are: putting public values at the center of new innovations; involving citizens and other stakeholders; respecting relevant laws and regulations; ensuring quality of data, algorithms and analysis; being transparent and accountable; monitoring, evaluating and adjusting if necessary; and paying attention to the safety of technology.

In July 2019, the Dutch central bank (De Nederlandsche Bank, "DNB") published guidelines containing general principles for the use of AI in the financial sector. These guidelines serve as a discussion paper and contain DNB's preliminary views on the responsible use of AI in the financial sector. The AFM has identified "digitalisation" as one of the trends for its strategy in 2023–2026. Its strategy promotes responsible decision-making frameworks amongst market participants while using AI applications and innovative products or services. Moreover, The Netherlands was the first European country to have a formal scheme for certified AI compliance officers in place. Today, over 800 professionals are licensed under the European CAICO mark and serve in public and private organisations.

Proposed AI Regulatory Authority and Future Outlook

The RDI's November 2024 report emphasizes the need for collaboration between various supervisory authorities, with both centralized and sector-specific oversight. The report calls for swift action to appoint the necessary supervisory bodies before the European AI Regulation's implementation in early 2025. Results from regulatory sandboxes and ongoing research will feed directly into secondary legislation and technical guidelines, ensuring the Netherlands' domestic framework evolves in lock-step with both EU requirements and local socio-economic needs. Taken together, the Netherlands' structured, EU-coordinated approach aims to unlock AI's economic and social value while safeguarding fundamental rights and public trust—anchoring the country's role as a responsible AI innovator within the European Union.

Dutch National AI Strategy

The Netherlands' AI governance approach is grounded in a value-driven, EU-aligned framework that combines ethical safeguards, public sector leadership, and technological innovation to promote responsible AI deployment. Through instruments like the SAPAI, the government's vision on generative AI, and emerging regulatory mechanisms, the Netherlands fosters context-sensitive, inclusive, and trustworthy AI adoption.

The Netherlands' AI governance model is built on foundational principles including human-centricity, fairness, transparency, and respect for individual and collective rights—values strongly aligned with EU and OECD guidelines. While the EU AI Act provides the overarching legislative framework, the Netherlands' approach complements this through its SAPAI, a comprehensive document from 2019 that defines ethical, regulatory, and innovation pathways for AI development. Unlike Singapore's voluntary, sector-led frameworks, the Netherlands leans on coordinated public governance and alignment with EU mandates, promoting national cohesion and international interoperability.

A defining trait of the Netherlands' model is its emphasis on inclusive and rights-based governance. The SAPAI explicitly outlines the importance of embedding public values and human rights into AI development and deployment. The government champions public trust by operationalizing these values through various initiatives, including the "human-centred approach" to AI and the ongoing efforts to identify competent authorities for AI supervision under the EU AI Act. The AP plays a crucial role in overseeing compliance with data protection laws, which are fundamental to responsible AI. The Netherlands also adopts a context-aware and risk-sensitive stance. The SAPAI prioritizes societal benefits and addresses challenges, supporting AI deployment in areas like healthcare, public services, and education—balancing innovation with proportional governance. While not explicitly called an "AI Sandbox" like Spain's, the Netherlands advocates for the use of regulatory sandboxes to ensure responsible AI deployment.

The SAPAI advocates for embedding AI governance into both corporate operations and public administration. It identifies key pillars such as scientific research, talent development, and ethical and regulatory frameworks. Responsibility for ethical deployment is distributed across developers, public institutions, and civil society, aligning with cooperative governance models while maintaining state-led coordination. The Ministry of Finance's research framework for mapping algorithmic control within government organizations further demonstrates this commitment. Capacity building, regional equity, and inclusion are also central to the Netherlands' framework. The SAPAI emphasizes the need for excellent educational opportunities to work with AI and aims to increase the availability of usable data for AI applications. The government's vision on generative AI further underscores the goal for AI to serve human well-being, prosperity, sustainability, justice, and security. These social objectives parallel Singapore's skills and inclusivity programmes, though the Netherlands emphasizes welfare-state reinforcement and democratic cohesion as core governance imperatives.

Finally, the Netherlands' approach is not static. The SAPAI is presented as a living document, and the government regularly publishes updates and visions, such as the recent vision on generative AI in January 2024. This mirrors Singapore's agile governance model, though the Netherlands' use of national institutions to guide such evolution underscores a more structured and institutionalized path toward AI maturity.

Approach to AI Regulation

The Netherlands has positioned itself as a proactive participant in shaping AI governance within the European Union, building dedicated programmes and “test-bed” zones while aligning closely with EU legislation. Without passing standalone AI-specific laws, the Netherlands is fostering responsible AI development through strategic initiatives, ethical principles and regulatory innovation aimed at creating a robust, human-centric AI ecosystem.

1. Regulatory and Strategic Frameworks

The Netherlands’ approach is anchored in direct application of the EU AI Act. Supplementing this EU-first stance are non-binding national instruments: In October 2019, the Dutch government published the SAPAI, outlining its plans for the future of AI in the Netherlands and its intentions to accelerate AI development and raise its international profile. The Dutch government also published an enclosed parliamentary letter on AI, public values, and human rights, discussing the opportunities and risks of AI and existing general policies in which AI occurs. In January 2024, the Dutch government presented its vision for

generative AI, emphasizing the importance of acting on AI's opportunities and risks. This vision focuses on the impact of generative AI on society, particularly concerning public values such as non-discrimination, privacy, and transparency. The government centralises the following principles: generative AI in the Netherlands is developed and applied safely and fairly; serves human well-being and autonomy; and contributes to sustainability and prosperity. The Dutch "human-centred approach" to AI means that respect for public values based on human rights is the starting point behind the purpose, design and use of AI. AI should reinforce public values and human rights rather than weaken them. To encourage compliance learning, the Netherlands advocates for the use of regulatory sandboxes to ensure responsible AI deployment.

2. Institutional Support and Strategic Missions

Although a permanent AI authority is still to be named, the Netherlands is building institutional capacity on several fronts: In November 2024, the RDI published its report titled "Final Advice on the Organisation of AI Supervision in the Netherlands," which outlines recommendations for the governance and supervision of AI systems in the Netherlands. The report emphasises the need for collaboration between various supervisory authorities, with both centralised and sector-specific oversight. The AP is designated as the "market supervisor" for high-risk AI systems, tasked with ensuring compliance with principles such as transparency and human oversight. Specific sectoral supervisors are mentioned to oversee AI applications within their respective domains.

3. Standards Development and Global Engagement

The Netherlands aligns national efforts with international AI ethics and standard-setting discussions. It contributes to European initiatives such as the European AI Progress. The AP's 2023 Annual Plan mentioned algorithms and AI as focus areas. The AP also refers to the Hiroshima AI Process, an international initiative established at the G7 Summit in May 2023, to develop international principles and a voluntary code of conduct for developers, complementing existing regional initiatives. Additionally, in October 2023, the United Nations established an AI Advisory Body to provide advice on international and inclusive governance of algorithms and AI. These initiatives will complement existing global cooperation within UNESCO and the OECD.

4. Sectoral and Extended Regulatory Approaches

No sector-specific AI statute exists yet, but existing Dutch and EU rules already influence AI deployments. The AP supervises the processing of personal data to

ensure compliance with laws that regulate the use of personal data. The tasks and powers of the AP are described in the General Data Protection Regulation (“GDPR”), supplemented by the Dutch Implementation Act of the GDPR. Companies using big data, machine learning, and AI must ensure they follow the principles from the GDPR. Insurance sector: DNB has paid attention to the use of AI by insurers through various studies, such as the DNB/AFM reconnaissance “AI in the insurance sector” from 2018 and the “DNB Insurtech Theme Study” from 2019–2020. Antitrust/competition laws: In 2020, the ACM published a position paper as a starting point to further develop its supervision regarding algorithmic applications. For the ACM, algorithmic applications are relevant when they play a role in activities that affect its supervisory domains, such as determining prices, steering supply and demand on the energy market, or personalising supply towards consumers.

5. Fostering Innovation and Indigenous Development

Innovation policy revolves around open experimentation, R&D incentives and SME support: The Dutch government is increasingly encouraging the deployment of innovative technologies, such as AI, emphasising proactive measures to harness its opportunities and mitigate its risk. Toolboxes help give a starting point to developers and administrators wanting to innovate in an ethical manner, with respect for important public values and fundamental rights. The government has asked the Social and Economic Council of the Netherlands to map out the impact of AI on labour productivity, quantity, and quality of work.

6. AI in Public-Sector Transformation

In July 2023, efforts were made by the Ministry of Finance to map out algorithmic control through a research framework. The research framework is primarily intended as a tool for auditors to investigate the control and operation of algorithms within government organisations. The algorithm register is currently live and includes over 700 algorithms, contributed by various governmental bodies such as the Municipality of Amsterdam and the Dutch Social Insurance Bank. The AP’s 2023 Annual Plan mentioned algorithms and AI as focus areas, and in January 2023, the AP announced it was creating a new organisational unit: the Coordination Algorithms Directorate, which supervises algorithms and coordinates the work of the various regulators with competencies in supervising algorithms and AI.

7. AI Skills, Education and Inclusion

The Dutch government underscores the need for action to harness both the opportunities and challenges of this rapidly evolving technology. It emphasises that generative AI should serve human wellbeing, prosperity, sustainability, justice and security.

8. Infrastructure, Compute and Data Foundations

While compute capacity is still emerging, the Netherlands participates in EU super-computing and data-space initiatives. Increasing data-related problems have led to specific legislation in the EU, such as the Platform-to-Business Regulation (“P2B Regulation”), the Digital Markets Act, the Digital Services Act, the Data Governance Act, and the Data Act. As of November 8, 2023, the ACM is authorised to supervise compliance with the P2B Regulation. The ACM has published Guidelines for Promoting a transparent and fair online platform economy for businesses, providing guidance on obligations arising from the P2B Regulation. The AFM and DNB have also increased their focus on data mobility in relation to the financial sector, and published a discussion paper with a preliminary policy vision on this subject. Both regulators mention that opportunities to share data can bring benefits, but must keep attention to the privacy and interests of data subjects.

Working together in
public-/private-
partnerships

Commitment to
international
cooperation

Promotion of
country as at
forefront of AI
innovation

Approach to Foster Innovation

The Netherlands' comprehensive approach to AI governance, deployment, and innovation is rooted in human-centric values, resilience-based planning, and globally coordinated action. The SAPAI and the government's vision on generative AI align with international ethical standards and outline strategic objectives aimed at addressing national challenges, enhancing industrial competitiveness, and achieving societal well-being through AI. The Netherlands' implementation spans across critical domains—from education and infrastructure to public services and international collaboration—enabling responsible AI adoption and long-term societal transformation.

1. Unlocking Economic Value through Targeted AI Deployment

The Netherlands' AI strategy focuses on leveraging AI to solve pressing national issues and drive value creation in real-world industries. The SAPAI identifies societal and economic opportunities through AI across various sectors, including healthcare, public services, and entrepreneurship. By deploying AI in these high-impact sectors, the Netherlands aims to enhance productivity, improve public services, and contribute to overall societal well-being.

2. Catalysing Innovation through Strategic Clustering and Ecosystems

The Netherlands fosters innovation through its strong research and innovation ecosystem, which includes leading universities, research institutions, and collaborative initiatives like the AIC4NL. These entities lead research in various AI domains. Strategic partnerships between academia, government, and industry are encouraged to co-create and rapidly implement cutting-edge AI technologies. The SAPAI emphasizes high-quality AI research and innovation that is leading in Europe.

3. Enabling Trusted and Responsible Data Use

The Netherlands emphasizes responsible AI, integrating cybersecurity with privacy-preserving technologies. These efforts are guided by the "human-centred approach" to AI, which prioritizes respect for public values and human rights. The government's vision on generative AI also highlights the importance of safe and fair development and application of AI.

4. Scaling AI in the Public Sector

The Dutch government promotes digital transformation through AI integration in public administration. AI is applied to enhance efficiency and effectiveness in public tasks. The Ministry of Finance's efforts to map algorithmic control through a research framework demonstrate the focus on transparent and accountable use of AI in government. The public algorithm register further promotes transparency in government algorithms.

5. Advancing Compute and Research Infrastructure

The Netherlands is investing in R&D infrastructure and compute resources to build a globally competitive AI ecosystem. The SAPAI calls for high-quality digital and intelligent connectivity and computing power for effective AI applications. This includes support for participation in strategic, large-scale European R&D cooperation programs, aiming to stimulate more Dutch research and development activities in AI.

6. Empowering SMEs and Startups

Support for SMEs and AI startups is integral to the Netherlands' strategy. The SAPAI aims to stimulate AI entrepreneurship. Targeted support includes fostering an environment where AI startups can thrive and contribute to the economy.

7. Developing a Future-Ready Workforce

The Netherlands aims to develop a future-ready workforce capable of working with AI. The SAPAI emphasizes excellent educational opportunities to engage

with AI and to cultivate more talent in the field. The government's initiatives focus on expanding skills and knowledge in AI across various sectors.

8. Aligning AI Innovation with Sustainability Goals

While not explicitly termed "AI for Planetary Resilience" as in Japan, the Netherlands' vision for generative AI emphasizes that it should contribute to sustainability and prosperity. The broader focus on societal well-being in the SAPAI implies the use of AI to address various societal challenges, which can include environmental and sustainability goals.

9. Building Public Trust and Ethical AI

The Netherlands' AI governance framework is grounded in a "human-centred approach," emphasizing respect for public values and human rights. The government supports the development of transparent and accountable AI systems, promoting public confidence through initiatives like the Toolbox for Ethically Responsible Innovation and the AP's focus on algorithms. Ethical AI is also addressed through active participation in international forums.

10. Shaping Global AI Governance and Standards

The Netherlands actively contributes to international AI standards and policy through platforms such as the European AI Progress and by participating in initiatives like the Hiroshima AI Process. The country's commitment to responsible AI and data interoperability positions it as a contributor to global thought leadership in ethical and resilient AI deployment. The Netherlands co-hosted the REAIM Summit in 2023, further demonstrating its commitment to shaping global AI governance.

Digital Decade

2025: Report

As of 2024, 23.06% of businesses in the Netherlands reported using AI technologies—substantially surpassing the EU average of 13.48%. This progress places the country on a strong trajectory toward its national 2030 AI adoption goal of 75%, with an internal projection suggesting an even more ambitious 85.1% adoption rate. This represents a notable increase from 2023, when AI usage stood at 14.1%, translating to an annual growth rate of 63.5%.

While the overall AI uptake exceeds the EU average, the adoption gap between SMEs and large enterprises remains significant. In 2024, only 21.9% of Dutch SMEs had implemented AI solutions (compared to the EU average of 12.64%), while 54.07% of large enterprises were using AI (above the EU average of 41.17%). The 32.17 percentage point difference between SME and large enterprise adoption slightly surpasses the EU-wide gap of 28.53 points.

The Dutch National Statistical Institute's 2024 AI Monitor indicates that businesses most frequently use AI for text mining (13.5%) and natural language generation (12.3%). AI adoption is most prevalent in the information and communication sector (58%), followed by business services (39.8%) and financial services (37.3%).

Among companies not using AI, 74.6% cited a lack of knowledge as the main barrier, while over half expressed concerns about privacy and data use.

A report by TechLeap offers deeper insight into the AI business ecosystem. It defines “AI companies” as those integrating AI at the core of their operations, developing algorithms or infrastructure, producing related hardware, or acting as end-users. These firms make up 9% of all Dutch tech scale-ups, many of which are newly established and seeking early-stage funding. Key obstacles include limited access to venture capital, lack of industry awareness, market entry difficulties for small firms, and shortages in talent, data, and computing power. Additionally, Dutch venture capitalists often hesitate to invest in AI due to perceived risks. Regulatory burdens and ethical concerns also pose challenges.

Much of the AI innovation in the Netherlands is supported by regional public-private partnerships. A cornerstone of this approach is the formerly known Dutch AI Coalition, backed by central government bodies and comprising over 500 organisations. It operates through regional AI hubs across the country. For example, AI Hub Amsterdam focuses on applications in healthcare, innovation, and citizen services, while AI Hub Brainport specialises in mobility, healthcare, and manufacturing.

In 2025, the Dutch AI Coalition joined forces with AiNed, which led to formation of the AIC4NL. to further drive national AI innovation. Among their initiatives was the AiNed MIT call for projects in 2024, which provided €3.55 million in grants to 14 SME-led AI projects. Another funding round is scheduled for 2025, alongside the launch of five applied learning communities, four innovation labs, and preparations for new European Language and Speech Technology AI labs.

The regionalised approach to AI development in the Netherlands presents a dual reality. While fragmented funding can hinder smaller firms, localised efforts bring strengths through diverse regional visions and agendas. Notably, Amsterdam’s municipality collaborated with residents in 2024 to craft an AI strategy centred on enhancing decision-making and building a smarter, ethically grounded city. Similarly, the Union of Water Boards introduced an AI compass to guide ethical AI use in the water sector, while the Association of Provincial Authorities released a Digital Ethics Guide, including guidance on AI practices.

Beyond regional initiatives, the Dutch government is committed to scaling up AI infrastructure and attracting talent. Moreover, a national AI Factory has been established to enhance computational capabilities.

The Netherlands is actively working to mitigate AI-related risks and ensure alignment with EU regulatory frameworks. Key measures include the National Algorithm and AI Register for the public sector, the release of a national vision on Generative AI in January 2024, and the adoption of an AI Regulation Guide in October 2024 to help stakeholders interpret and comply with the EU AI Act.

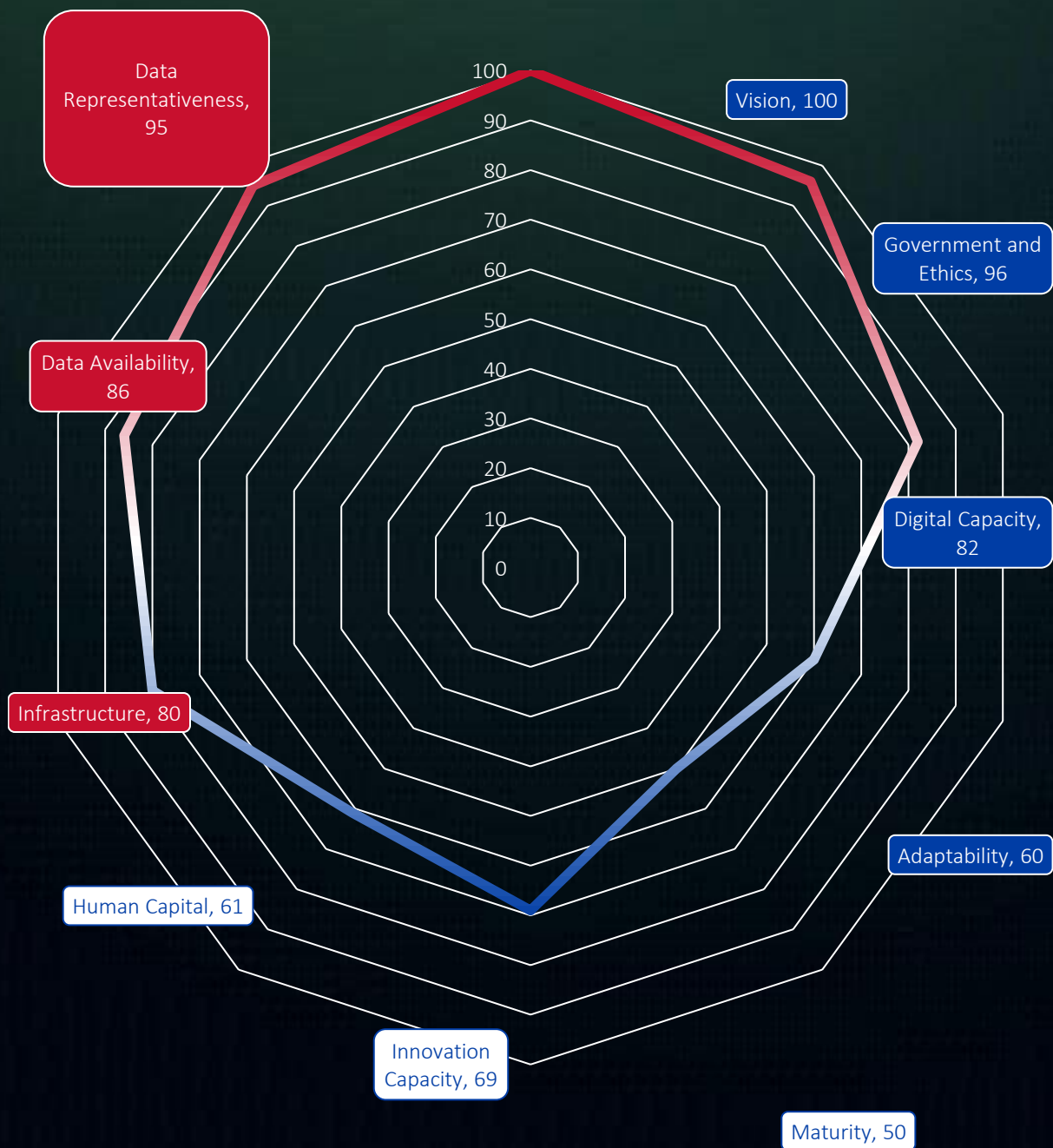
Finally, the 2025 Eurobarometer reveals that 88% of Dutch citizens believe public authorities should take a leading role in shaping AI and other emerging technologies to ensure compliance with EU values and fundamental rights.



Government AI Readiness

Western Europe ranks as the highest-performing region in this year's Government AI Readiness Index, with five countries in the global top 10. France leads the regional ranking with a score of 79.36, narrowly ahead of the United Kingdom (78.88), followed closely by the Netherlands (77.23), Germany (76.90), and Finland (76.48). With an average regional score of 69.56, Western Europe outperforms the global average (47.59) across all three pillars of Government, Technology, and Data & Infrastructure. The region's standout strength is the Data & Infrastructure pillar, where it averages 81.91, more than 21 points above the global benchmark (59.62), reflecting its advanced digital infrastructure and high-quality data environment.

2024 Scores by Dimension



Government

The Netherlands posts a Government-pillar score of 84.58, reflecting an active institutional push to operationalise the EU AI Act and embed trustworthy-AI principles across the public sector. The country has already identified and designating its national authorities responsible for overseeing and enforcing compliance with EU fundamental rights legislation in the context of AI. Regulatory experimentation is supported by the advocacy for the use of regulatory sandboxes, which allow for responsible AI deployment. Fundamental-rights safeguards stem from the Dutch government's emphasis on a "human-centred approach" to AI, ensuring respect for public values and human rights. The Ministry of Finance's efforts to map algorithmic control within government organizations and the public algorithm register provide concrete frameworks and transparency for lawful deployment. Together, these measures underpin a government model that couples EU alignment with robust oversight and capacity-building.

Technology Sector

A Technology-pillar score of 60.12 signals a maturing and active innovation ecosystem. The Netherlands' AI market is expanding, fueled by a strong research base and collaborative initiatives like the AIC4NL. The SAPAI aims to stimulate AI entrepreneurship and foster an environment where AI startups can thrive. The government's vision on generative AI further emphasizes harnessing the opportunities of this rapidly evolving technology. Continued support for research and development, particularly through participation in European R&D cooperation programs, will be critical to further strengthen the technology innovation base and maintain its leading position in Europe.

Data & infrastructure Sector

With a score of 87.00, the Netherlands exhibits strong digital foundations and a forward-looking data-governance agenda. National policy aligns with EU instruments such as the Data Governance Act, the Digital Markets Act, the Digital Services Act, and the Data Act. The DNB and the AFM have also increased their focus on data mobility within the financial sector. The SAPAI calls for high-quality digital and intelligent connectivity and computing power for effective AI

applications. These initiatives, coupled with robust broadband penetration and an expanding open-data culture, create favorable conditions for large-scale, data-driven AI projects across the economy.

The Netherlands' composite score of 77.23 places it among the highest-performing countries in Western Europe and comfortably outpaces the global mean (47.59). High scores in the Government and Data & Infrastructure pillars indicate strong foundational strengths, while the Technology pillar, though lower, still reflects a significant and growing innovation ecosystem. Continued progress on supervisory structures, support for innovation, and active participation in international AI governance discussions should consolidate the existing strong position.



Conclusion

The Netherlands has established itself as a principled, innovation-driven leader in artificial intelligence, combining EU-aligned regulatory discipline with a strong domestic ecosystem rooted in ethics, public trust, and multi-stakeholder collaboration. While the country benefits from advanced digital infrastructure, a robust supervisory architecture, and a vibrant research and innovation landscape, its continued global leadership will depend on accelerating commercial adoption, expanding compute and data capabilities, and translating pilot-stage experimentation into large-scale, responsibly governed deployment.

The Netherlands stands at a decisive juncture in its AI evolution. Over the past decade, the country has built one of Europe's most coherent and values-driven AI governance frameworks, characterised by a supervisory-first approach that integrates the EU AI Act with national institutions, ethical principles, and sector-specific oversight. This alignment has created a strong baseline for responsible AI development, supported by clearly defined authorities such as the AP, the Netherlands Institute for Human Rights, and existing sectoral regulators. The emphasis on regulatory sandboxes, algorithmic transparency, and human-

centred design demonstrates a mature understanding of both the opportunities and risks that accompany widespread AI adoption.

Yet the Netherlands' position as an early mover also brings new challenges. Although research output and innovation capacity remain high, national contributions to global AI research have plateaued in recent years. This reflects both heightened global competition and internal constraints, including limited R&D scale, fragmented adoption among SMEs, and gaps in compute power and data interoperability. The country's strong foundations in responsible AI, privacy, and data governance must therefore be more tightly coupled with accelerated deployment, stronger public-private translation mechanisms, and strategic investments in next-generation infrastructure. The Netherlands' regional innovation model—powered by the AIC4NL, and multiple sectoral hubs—represents a powerful engine for experimentation and applied research. However, translating this momentum into consistent nationwide uptake will require reducing fragmentation, expanding cross-regional coordination, and providing SMEs with clearer pathways from pilot to scale. In parallel, demand for advanced AI talent continues to outpace supply, underscoring the importance of sustained educational investment, international recruitment, and targeted upskilling across the public and private sectors.

Policy developments, including the national vision on generative AI, the public algorithm register, and the Digitalisation Strategy, reinforce the Netherlands' long-term commitment to trustworthy and accountable AI. These instruments provide an important foundation for navigating emerging risks, including generative-AI safety, algorithmic bias, and data governance challenges. Continued transparency—through public reporting, impact assessments, and cross-agency collaboration—will be essential to maintain public trust at a time when societal expectations around accountability and rights-protection are rapidly increasing. Looking ahead, the Netherlands has an opportunity to consolidate its role as Europe's "ultimate AI launchpad." Achieving this ambition will require scaling compute capacity, deepening engagement with international standards bodies, accelerating market adoption, and strengthening mechanisms that link ethical principles with real-world implementation. By combining its longstanding commitment to public values with strategic economic investment and agile regulatory design, the Netherlands can continue shaping an AI ecosystem that is globally competitive, socially responsible, and resilient in the face of rapid technological change.

Appendix A:

Expert Vignettes

This appendix presents short expert vignettes that illustrate how the Netherlands' institutional landscape for AI oversight, coordination and policy implementation operates in practice. Each vignette is written from the perspective of a typical actor (role-based, anonymised) and highlights institutional responsibilities, accountability arrangements and multi-stakeholder mechanisms that shape trustworthy, inclusive and adaptive AI governance



Sigrid Berge van Rooijen, *Health AI Consultant*, Eir Health

The Dutch government is trying to support preparation for the AI Act by providing guidelines and online decision support. Even though tools are available from the government's side, many organizations don't know what steps to take to be compliant.



Biography

Sigrid Berge van Rooijen is a pioneering figure in the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) within the healthcare sector. Her journey into this field was deeply personal, motivated by the realization that AI could have played a crucial role in her father's cancer treatment. This experience started a passion to ensure that healthcare professionals understand and can use the potential of AI to improve patient outcomes. With a strong scientific and clinical background, Sigrid has become a leading voice in educating various levels of the healthcare industry about AI. She has conducted numerous training sessions for doctors' associations, hospital laboratories, health departments, and mental health providers. Her expertise extends to pioneering remote patient consultations, remote monitoring, and digital lifestyle counseling, and a focus on the multidisciplinary perspective. Sigrid's work focuses on supporting healthcare organizations in understanding AI's applications, ensuring that its implementation is ethical, prioritizes patient safety, and maximizes impact. Sigrid empowers non-technical healthcare professionals to trust and adopt AI technology, while also guiding healthcare organizations to use AI responsibly. Her vision is to make it easier for these organizations to find and adopt AI tools, ultimately reducing workload, improving patient care, and improving the quality of life for both healthcare professionals and patients. Through her tireless efforts, Sigrid is shaping the future of healthcare by bridging the gap between technology and patient care.

Arnoud Engelfriet, *Chief Knowledge Officer*, ICTRecht

Legal certainty will come from operational discipline: transparent models, traceable data flows, and documented human oversight. The AI Act rewards organisations that can evidence their choices—not those that merely assert good intentions.



Biography

Arnoud Engelfriet is a leading authority on the intersection of law, technology, and governance, known for translating complex AI regulation into practical, operational guidance for organisations. With a background spanning computer science, IP law, and digital-rights scholarship, Arnoud has spent more than two decades helping public institutions, companies, and policymakers navigate emerging technologies responsibly. His work is driven by a simple conviction: AI can only earn societal trust when its use is transparent, accountable, and demonstrably lawful. This principle underpins his extensive contributions, from writing the authoritative guide *The Annotated AI Act* and building various AI compliance training programmes, to advising organisations on compliance-by-design, algorithmic oversight, and fundamental-rights risk mitigation. Arnoud regularly trains legal professionals, compliance teams, and regulators, focusing on how to operationalise the EU AI Act through documentation, human oversight, and verifiable governance processes. Beyond consultancy and scholarship, Arnoud advocates for evidence-based, rights-centred AI deployment across both public and private sectors. His work aims to make it easier for organisations to understand their obligations, reduce risk, and implement AI systems that enhance—not undermine—public values. Through this blend of legal expertise and practical tooling, he continues to shape the emerging discipline of AI compliance and support a trustworthy digital future for the Netherlands and Europe.

Jousef Murad, *Founder & Lead Engineer*, APEX Consulting

From our POV, the opportunity is clear: those who structure their AI systems early will be able to scale faster, operate safer, and build long-term trust with customers and partners. It's now less about AI workflows and agents but more about clear, safe and easy-to-maintain AI architecture.



What is the state of AI regulation implementation in the Netherlands?

The Netherlands is in an active transition phase. The EU AI Act is adopted, but the practical rollout is still underway. Dutch companies are aware they must comply, but many aren't sure where to start. You see a clear split in the market: larger enterprises are already mapping their AI use cases and risk categories, while SMEs and agencies often rely on ad-hoc tools without governance. The government is preparing support programs, but implementation guidance is still fragmented.

In day-to-day client work, this means there's a lot of uncertainty, many misconceptions, and a growing need for standardized AI governance frameworks, documentation, and risk assessments. We as an agency have to do a lot of work still to explain to organizations what is possible and what is not possible!

Why is the Netherlands well suited for AI regulatory requirements?

From your perspective as an AI automation agency owner, the Netherlands is one of the most promising places to operationalize compliance because:

- The digital infrastructure is strong and companies are used to adopting new tech early.
- Dutch business culture values transparency, documentation, and process thinking, which aligns naturally with regulatory demands.
- There's high trust in institutions and strong privacy awareness from years of GDPR maturity.
- Many industries (finance, logistics, healthcare, manufacturing) already run structured quality systems and certifications, making AI governance a logical next layer rather than a disruption. In practice, this means Dutch companies adapt faster, and they're willing to invest in automation and compliance tooling when the impact is clearly defined.

Which challenges are most relevant for Dutch entrepreneurs?

Your clients consistently struggle with three categories of challenges:

- **Understanding what actually applies to them** - Most companies are unsure whether their AI usage is “minimal risk”, “limited risk”, or “high risk”. They overestimate or underestimate the legal impact, which leads to either paralysis or risky shortcuts.
- **Lack of internal expertise** - Entrepreneurs don't have AI risk officers or technical compliance staff. Many use AI on a daily basis (ChatGPT, internal agents or marketing automations) but lack documentation, auditing, and safeguards. They need practical frameworks rather than legal theory.
- **Balancing innovation with compliance** - The biggest fear you notice is that compliance will slow down growth. Entrepreneurs worry that governance requirements will kill speed. What they really need is a system that integrates compliance into existing workflows without adding bureaucracy.

Biography

Jousef Murad is a mechanical engineer, consultant, and founder of APEX Consulting, specializing in B2B marketing, sales automation, AI-driven business optimization & lead gen. With a computational fluid dynamics (CFD) & AI background, he bridges engineering and marketing, helping companies refine processes and scale growth. He also hosts the Digital Renaissance & Engineered-Mind Podcast sharing insights on LinkedIn (171K+ followers), YouTube, and other platforms.

More information accessible at: <https://jousefmurad.com/>.

Appendix B: OECD AI Progress Report

This note summarises the OECD country note on the Netherlands' progress implementing its 2019 AI strategy (Strategic Action Plan for Artificial Intelligence, SAPAI) and subsequent integration into broader national digital strategies.

The Netherlands' 2019 SAPAI laid a durable foundation by combining innovation, skills and ethics — and policymakers have pursued a coherent approach by embedding AI actions into successive national digitalisation and economy strategies. Institutional coordination across ministries (Digitalisation, Economic Affairs, Justice & Security, Foreign Affairs and Education) has supported a whole-of-government response that balances regulatory preparedness with support for market uptake. The 2024 government vision on generative AI is an important, early national framing that foregrounds safety, equity, human welfare and sustainability while setting concrete action points for collaboration, skills, monitoring and enforcement.

Strengths

- **Integrated policy architecture:** AI is not siloed — SAPAI's priorities have been woven into the Dutch Digitalisation Strategy, the Value-Driven Digitalisation Work Agenda and the 2023 Digital Economy Strategy, which helps align regulation, R&D and uptake.

- **Public–private scale and funding:** Large, sustained initiatives (AIC4NL; NOLAI) and funds for innovation-to-market (Invest-NL, EDIHs) create pathways from lab to deployment. AIC4NL’s multi-hundred-million public backing and ROBUST research investments illustrate serious resource commitment.
- **Regional innovation ecosystem:** Seven regional AI hubs plus multiple EDIHs foster sectoral clusters (health, energy, agriculture) and help SMEs experiment with AI.
- **Data and computing focus:** The CoE-DSC, GAIA-X Hub and IPCEI-CIS activity strengthen federated data spaces, cloud interoperability and HPC capacity — essential enablers of high-value AI.
- **Sectoral leadership in healthcare and agriculture:** Legal and technical moves to standardise EHRs (Wegiz), pilots on human-rights impact assessments and AI-driven proton therapy planning show targeted, practical deployments.

Constraints and risks

- **Data fragmentation vs. central enforcement:** While technical standards (ZIBs) and Wegiz move interoperability forward, decentralised storage and legacy systems still create silos that limit scalable, secure data reuse for AI.
- **Scaling from pilots to market:** Many initiatives are strong at piloting and proof-of-concept stage; converting these into wide commercial uptake—particularly among SMEs—remains challenging without broader financing and procurement incentives.
- **Transparency and accountability:** Steps such as the algorithm and AI register (2024) and IAMA pilots are positive; sustained transparency requires public reporting on impact assessments, enforcement actions and outcomes.
- **Talent pipeline vs. demand:** NOLAI and Human Capital Agenda actions address skills, but demand for specialised AI and HPC expertise is high; more rapid upskilling and attraction of international talent will be needed to sustain ambitious R&D and deployment goals.

Practical recommendations (constructive next steps)

1. **Accelerate enforceable data governance:** Build on Wegiz and CoE-DSC to create clearer incentives and streamlined processes for safe, cross-

institutional data access (e.g., standard APIs, certified data intermediaries, and legal guidance for data pooling).

2. **Scale regulatory sandboxes and SME pathways:** Expand EDIH-style support with targeted fiscal and procurement levers so SMEs can move from pilots to commercialisation (matchmaking with Invest-NL and public procurement trials).
3. **Publish impact and enforcement reporting:** Regular, public progress reports on deployed AI systems (including IAMA outcomes and algorithm register data) would strengthen accountability and public trust.
4. **Boost HPC and green AI efforts:** Couple investments in HPC with incentives for energy-efficient model development and measurement of AI carbon footprints (aligning the Sustainable Digitalisation Action Plan with AI deployment).
5. **Deepen sectoral guidance (healthcare focus):** Fast-track practical, clinically-oriented AI guidelines and certification routes so hospitals and clinics can adopt validated generative-AI tools safely (building on Valuable AI for Health).

Overall, the OECD country note presents the Netherlands as a mature, well-resourced EU Member State that combines early ethical framing and strong regional ecosystems with meaningful investments in data infrastructure and talent. The near-term challenge is translating pilot successes and generous funding into broad, transparent, and sustainable market adoption while continuing to operationalise robust governance for generative AI and other rapidly evolving technologies.

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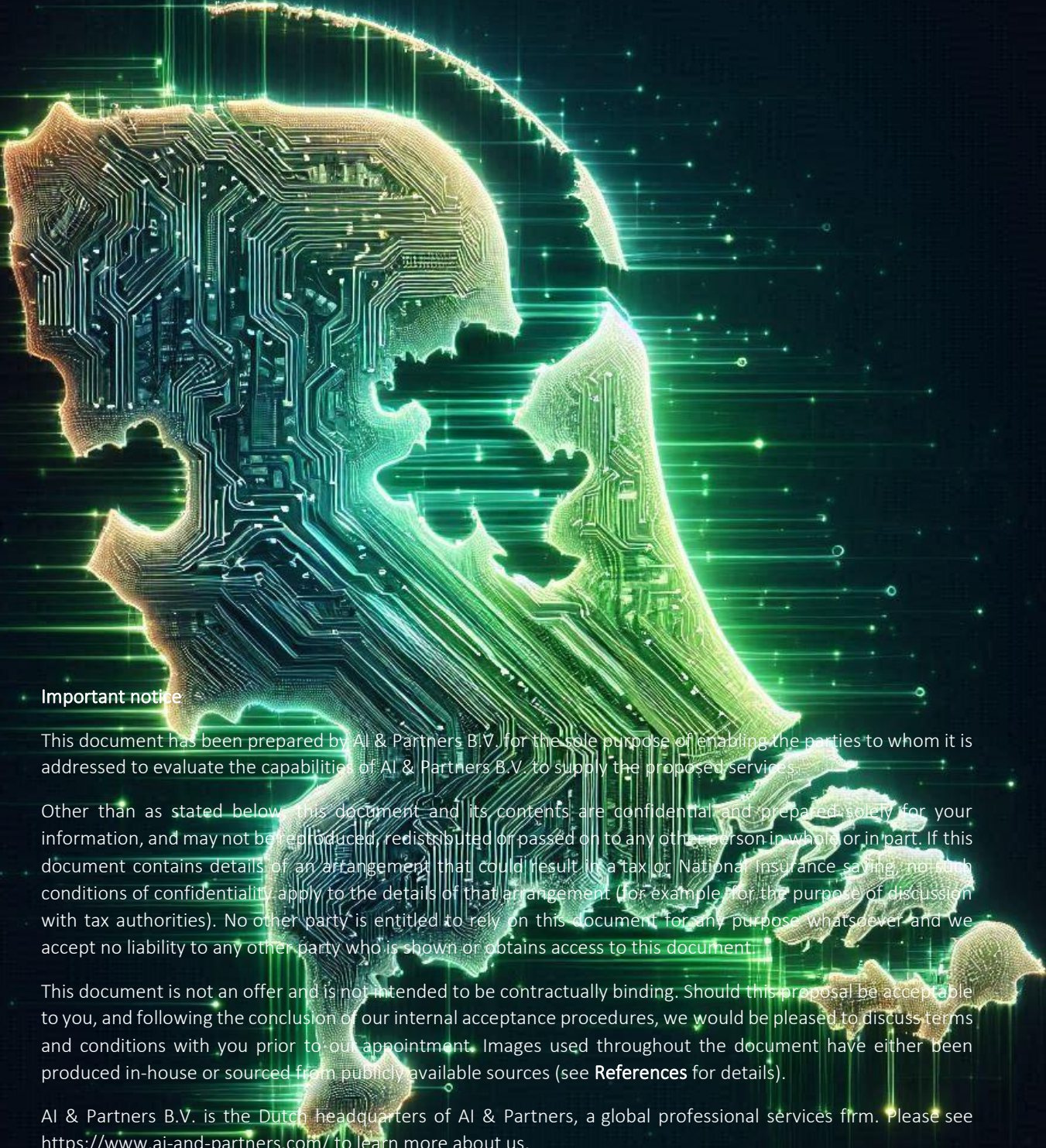
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